spoons of ghee and pigged out on the food in front of us. It soon became a regular thing and Jhanak bhai and his family fed us many times. Others who have been kind enough to provide us with good home-cooked food in Zimbabwe and South Africa are Raj and Chester Naik and Jayesh Desai. They have selflessly helped us whenever we have toured their parts of the world and have made a major contribution to our well-being. Raj and Chester Naik also took us to play golf and we had some wonderful dinners together. Invariably Ravi Shastri would join us for these dinners because they were his friends first. I became good friends with many of them and must say I will always remember the warmth and affection I received from them and their families.

Unacceptable allegations

We managed a better batting performance in the Port Elizabeth Test, which started on 16 November 2001. Rahul Dravid and Deep Dasgupta, our wicketkeeper, played resolutely on the last day, and we saved the match comfortably in the end. However, what hit the headlines from that match were the allegations made against me by the match referee Mike Denness, who also charged five other Indian players.

The incident occurred on the third day, when I bowled a four-over spell, taking the wicket of Herschelle Gibbs. I was bowling seam-up and was getting the ball to swing both ways. During this spell I used my thumb to clean off the grass that was stuck on the seam.

Soon after the end of the day's play we were informed that the match referee had called six Indian players for a hearing and that I had been accused of ball tampering. I was shocked, because I had always played cricket with integrity and honesty and would never do such a thing.

When I met the match referee I informed him that I was merely trying to clean the seam of the ball. My mistake, which I have no hesitation in owning up to, was that I should have informed the on-field umpires under Law 42.3 when I was cleaning the seam, but I'm afraid it did not enter my mind in the intensity of the moment. I asked Mike Denness to consult the on-field umpires, because they had checked the ball every two or three overs and were in the best position to tell if the ball had been tampered with. Denness said that there was no need to consult the umpires, presumably because I had admitted altering the ball by cleaning the seam.